

The Animal Welfare Task Group (AWTG) is a committee of officials from all Australian jurisdictions. It oversees the development of national animal welfare standards and guidelines. These aim to improve national consistency, making it easier for industry, the community and trading partners to understand animal welfare requirements. The standards are designed to be adopted in state and territory legislation, while guidelines are voluntary.

The Animal Welfare Task Group is chaired by Queensland, with the Commonwealth providing secretariat support.

Agriculture ministers agreed on 21 February 2020 that Queensland would lead the development of Australian Animal Welfare Standards and Guidelines for Livestock at Processing Establishments. A consultant is undertaking a scientific literature review—the first step in developing standards and guidelines. The literature review is expected to be complete in October 2021. Drafting work will commence in the meantime, building upon previous work led by New South Wales in 2017. A stakeholder advisory group will be convened in the second half of 2021 to review draft standards and guidelines and the outcomes of the literature review. Regulatory impact analysis will be undertaken as part of the process.

The Queensland Department of Agriculture and Fisheries is also leading a review of the suitability for horses of the existing Australian Animal Welfare Standards and Guidelines for the Land Transport of Livestock and is considering feedback from a stakeholder discussion paper. Refined proposals and, if required, a regulatory impact statement, will be provided for further consultation around August 2021.

For further information on the development of Australian Animal Welfare Standards and Guidelines for Livestock at Processing Establishments, and the review of the suitability for horses of the existing Australian Animal Welfare Standards and Guidelines for the Land Transport of Livestock, please contact AnimalWelfareProject@daf.qld.gov.au.

Further Information

Contact the secretariat: awtg@aff.gov.au

Post: AWTG c/- Department of Agriculture, Forestry and Fisheries,
GPO Box 858, Canberra ACT 2601, Australia

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/animal/welfare/awtg/communique-may-2021>